Bed Bath & Beyond stores seem well aware of which side of their bread is buttered. While their CEO is continually blaming declines in their profits on an increase in their available coupons, he has stubbornly refused to do away with the promotional “20% off” coupons. Why? Perhaps because they don’t want to lose their core of coupon-happy shoppers, the same core of coupon clippers who evidently stopped shopping at J. C. Penney stores when they discontinued their coupons.

“Like it or not, consumers are addicted to coupons, and they count on them,” Susan M. Jones, vice president of business development and marketing at CMS, Inc., which tracks coupon usage, reiterates in a *Baltimore Sun* article.

Yes, consumers can be addicted to using coupons. I freely admit my own addiction. Not only that, but as an avid refunder in the 1980s and 1990s, I was equally addicted to getting free things. For those of us who have been in the coupon buisiness for any length of time, refunding used to be synonymous with couponing. According to David Vaczek and Richard Sale in an August 1998 *Promo* magazine article about advertising promotions, refunds and premium offers also have a long history as a promotional tactic, going back as far as the early 1880s when Adolphus Busch, a beer seller from St. Louis, used to park his beer wagon in front of a saloon to give out free samples and premiums like jack-knives, stick pins, and watch fobs to his favorite customers. Refunds, unlike their coupon counterparts, offer a certain amount of money or a premium, like a T-shirt, hat, or stuffed toy sent to the buyer of the product in exchange for the consumer sending in certain proofs of purchase to the company. One hundred years after Busch’s